

ARP BLOGS

One Love

*A story of two hearts, one storm,
and the long road to peace*

ARP Blogs

First Edition · 2026

ARP Blogs · India

ARP Blogs

One Love

Copyright © 2026 by ARP Blogs

All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced or transmitted in any form or by any means without the prior written permission of the author, except in the case of brief quotations in critical reviews and articles.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are either products of the author's imagination or used fictitiously.

First Published 2026 · ARP Blogs · India

For

*every soul who has ever sat alone in a quiet room with the weight
of something they could not say out loud, and still woke up the next
morning and chose to try again.*

And for everyone who has loved without being chosen.

Your love was not wasted.

It made you who you are.

This one is yours.

*You don't love someone because they're perfect.
You love them in spite of the fact that they're not.*

Jodi Picoult

*The most painful thing is losing yourself
in the process of loving someone too much.*

Ernest Hemingway

*Loving someone who doesn't love you back
is like waiting for a ship at the airport.*

Unknown

Contents

Author's Note

Chapter One • The First Hello

Chapter Two • When Everything Was Enough

Chapter Three • The Season That Changed

Chapter Four • One Love, Still

Acknowledgements

About the Author

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Before the Story Begins

One Love · ARP Blogs

I did not sit down to write a love story. I sat down to write an honest one. There is a difference, a difference I did not fully understand until I was already halfway through.

Love stories, as we have inherited them, tend to be about arrival. The moment two people find each other. The confession. The kiss in the rain. The resolution that leaves everyone breathing easier. They are about love as a destination, a place you reach and then stay in, safely, forever.

What I wanted to write about was love as weather. Something that moves through you whether you invited it or not. Something that changes the temperature of everything, the way you sleep, the way you look at strangers on a train, the way ordinary Tuesday afternoons feel heavy and golden and unbearably full of meaning when someone you love has touched them.

I have known the particular silence of loving someone who, for a time, loved you back, and then, slowly and without meaning to, began to love someone else. I have known what it is to sit in a room with that person, still being their friend, still laughing when they laugh, still meaning every word of it, while something inside you bleeds quietly and refuses to stop.

Aryan is not entirely me. But he holds parts of me I have never shown anyone. Priya is not a villain. She falls the way most people fall, without warning, without permission, even from herself. Rohan does nothing wrong. He simply arrives. That, in the end, is the most frightening thing about him.

I wrote this in whatever time I could find, early mornings before the city woke up, late nights after everything else had gone quiet. I wrote it to understand something I had already lived through but could not yet name.

If you have ever loved someone who did not choose you, this book was written with you somewhere in the back of my mind. You are not less for what you felt. You are not broken, or foolish, or wrong. You loved honestly. In this world, that is a rarer thing than we are taught to believe.

There is peace on the other side. I have been there. I promise you, there is peace.

ARP Blogs, 2026

CHAPTER ONE

The First Hello

One Love · ARP Blogs

There are people you meet and forget before you even reach home. Their face blurs. Their name slips into the general noise of the world and disappears. The world moves on and so do you, and that is fine, that is simply how most meetings go.

And then there are people you meet once, just once, in passing, and no matter how many years pile up between that moment and now, no matter how much changes and is lost and rebuilt, something in you never quite lets them go. You carry them. Not as a burden, more like a song you heard once from a passing car on a summer night, and now, at the strangest moments, in a queue somewhere, in the space between sleeping and waking, you catch yourself humming it without knowing why.

Aryan Malhotra was the kind of person who arrived late to everything and apologised to no one. He had a theory about this, that lateness was not disrespect but a stubborn excess of optimism, a refusal to accept that the world was as rigid as it insisted on being. Time, he felt, ought to be a little more generous than advertised.

This theory had failed him consistently for two years.

It failed him again on the first day of second year, when he slid into the last empty seat in the lecture hall just as the professor

advanced to the third slide. The room was full of students bent over notebooks with the particular gravity of people who have already decided to take things seriously. Aryan was not one of those people, but he was, at least, present.

The last empty seat happened to be next to Priya.

She did not look up. She had a pen tucked behind her ear and a notebook already half-filled with careful, unhurried handwriting. She wrote the way some people breathe, steadily, without fuss, as though this had simply always been happening and always would be. Her eyes were on the whiteboard with an attention so complete it made Aryan feel, just for a moment, quietly ashamed of his own carelessness.

He watched her write for a few seconds. Then, because he could not help himself, he leaned slightly toward her and whispered: "Did I miss anything important?"

She turned slowly. The look she gave him was the look of someone who has just been asked the time by a person standing directly in front of a clock.

"Only the entire introduction," she said.

"So nothing, then."

She did not laugh. But the corner of her mouth shifted, barely, just barely, and in that small and reluctant movement, Aryan found something he had not been looking for.

His full name was Aryan Malhotra. He was twenty years old, from Delhi, studying literature because his father had wanted him to study

commerce and he had decided at seventeen that the most meaningful act of defiance available to him was poetry. He was lanky and perpetually underdressed and had the kind of laugh that entered a room a few seconds before he did.

Her name was Priya Sharma. She was twenty, from a small town in Rajasthan, the first person in three generations of her family to attend university. She had arrived at Sunrise University with two old suitcases, a scholarship she had worked three years to earn, and the particular gravity of someone who understands, deep in their bones, what it has cost to get somewhere. She was quiet. She chose her words the way you choose your steps on uncertain ground, carefully, with full attention, never wasting one.

They became friends the way rivers become rivers. Slowly. Without anyone deciding.

She started saving him the notes from lectures he slept through. He started walking her back to the hostel after the library sessions she never missed. She borrowed his worn paperbacks and returned them with small pencil marks in the margins that he never asked about, because they felt like they belonged there. He saved her a seat in the canteen without thinking, the way you do when saving a seat has stopped being a choice and become simply something your hands know how to do.

By October, the whole floor knew them as a pair. Not in the dramatic sense, not yet. But in the quiet, inevitable way that some people simply begin to inhabit the same gravity. Where one was, the other was nearby. It had simply become true, without anyone having made it so.

The day he told her was a Thursday in November. It had been raining since morning and the campus smelled of wet earth and old brick and the clean particular smell that rain gives to places that are already beautiful. They were sitting on the library steps sharing a bag of roasted peanuts, arguing about whether *The Kite Runner* was overrated, she said no, he said obviously yes, she said he had not read it properly, he said he had read it very properly and properly concluded it was overrated, when he turned mid-sentence and said, quietly, without planning any of it:

"I think I am in love with you."

He said it the way most true things are said, like a sentence that had simply been waiting long enough and had finally decided to stop waiting.

Priya looked at him. The rain was starting again, light and tentative. She looked at him the way she looked at everything, carefully, fully, without hurry.

"You always say things like they cost nothing," she said.

"This one cost quite a lot. I have been holding it since July."

She looked away toward the rain for a long moment. Then she looked back. And then she said, in the quiet voice she used for the things that mattered most to her:

"Me too."

That was all. No music. No grand gesture. No cinematic rain falling at exactly the right angle. Just two people on wet stone steps, in the middle of a completely silly argument about a novel, finding

the most important thing.

CHAPTER TWO

When Everything Was Enough

One Love · ARP Blogs

The months that followed were the kind you do not fully appreciate while you are living them. You look back later, years later, sometimes, and you see them with a clarity that simply was not available to you at the time, and you think: that was it. That was the warm, ordinary, irreplaceable middle of it. But while you are inside it, you just think: Tuesday. Library. The bench. Him. Her.

They moved through the rest of second year as though they had always been doing it together. The differences that had once made them feel like strangers, his chaos against her order, his ease against her seriousness, had softened into something else. Texture. The particular richness you get when two very different things are woven together properly.

He showed her things she had been too afraid to allow herself. Rest without guilt. Laughter as a real and legitimate response to difficulty. The strange and undervalued pleasure of an afternoon spent doing absolutely nothing useful on a patch of grass, watching clouds pass, talking about nothing in particular. She had always believed that rest was something you earned. He believed it was something you simply took, like air.

She showed him things he had never thought to want. The deep satisfaction of following through, of saying you will be somewhere and being there, every single time, without exception. The quiet dignity of real effort. The way that care, offered consistently and without expectation of return, builds something that lasts far longer than excitement. He had lived his entire life on excitement. She gave him something steadier.

They argued. Of course they argued. She thought he treated time the way someone treats something they have too much of. He thought she was too hard on herself in ways that no one who cared for her could witness without wanting to argue on her behalf. She went silent when she was hurt. He talked too much when he was nervous.

And yet. They worked. In the way that some things that have no right to work somehow, quietly, do.

Their place was a bench near the old banyan tree at the far eastern edge of the campus, past the science block, past the old water tower, past the point where the path stopped being maintained and became simply worn grass. Most evenings, as the campus lights came on one by one, it was only the two of them out there, in the warm dark, talking or not talking, which amounted to the same thing.

One February evening, Priya said: "Do you think this lasts?"

He turned to look at her. "What do you mean?"

"I mean us. This." She paused for a moment. "People always say that college love does not last. That it is just proximity. That once it ends, everyone realises it was never really what they thought it was."

He was quiet for a moment, long enough that she looked at him. Then he said: "I think the people who say that never had something worth surviving for."

She did not answer right away. But she reached over and took his hand, and he felt her exhale, slowly, all the way, the way someone exhales when they have been holding their breath without knowing it, and something has finally, gently, told them they are allowed to stop.

March came. Then April. The academic calendar moved around them and they moved through it together, without hurry, without the anxious scanning of the future that can quietly ruin the present if you let it.

He was, in those months, the happiest he had ever been, without knowing it, the way you never quite know the good times while you are inside them.

And then May came, and with it, Rohan.

CHAPTER THREE

The Season That Changed

One Love · ARP Blogs

Rohan Verma arrived at the start of the new academic year with the unhurried confidence of someone who has never once walked into a room and wondered whether he was wanted.

He had transferred from a university in Mumbai. He was tall, broad-shouldered, easy with a smile. He wore his charm the way some people wear a well-fitted jacket, naturally, without thinking about it, as though he had simply been born in it. He was generous and funny and remembered people's names and the small things they had mentioned in passing, the things they themselves had half-forgotten.

He joined Aryan's circle the way easy people join things, without friction, without effort, simply because a space existed and he moved into it. A shared professor. A study group. A regular table at the canteen.

Aryan liked him. That was the part that would come back to him later, like a strange and useless irony. He had genuinely, straightforwardly liked him.

The problem, if you could call it that, and later he would not be sure you could, was that Rohan liked Priya.

It did not announce itself. It never does. It was a series of moments, each one small enough to mean nothing by itself, which accumulated the way water accumulates in a low place, quietly, imperceptibly, until one morning you look and there is a flood where there was none.

A chair saved. A question directed toward her when it could have been directed at anyone. The habit of finding her in a crowded room. The way he listened when she spoke, not the polite half-attention that people offer each other in groups, but the full, unhurried attention of someone who finds what is being said genuinely worth hearing.

Aryan noticed. He noticed the way you notice something you immediately wish you had not, with a horrible, unwanted clarity, a sharpness that arrived without invitation and refused to leave.

He said nothing, because there was nothing to say. Rohan was never inappropriate. Never careless. He was, in fact, so careful that his carefulness was the thing that frightened Aryan most. Carelessness is accidental. Carefulness is deliberate. Carefulness says: I have thought about this. I am paying attention. This matters to me.

What he had not prepared himself for, what he could not have prepared for, was Priya.

She did not change overnight. Nothing real ever does. But she grew quieter around Aryan in ways she hadn't been before, not cold, never cold, but with an inward quality, as though she was listening to something he couldn't hear. And in Rohan's presence she was lighter. Not louder, not more open, just lighter. As though something she had

been carrying, without knowing she was carrying it, had been set briefly down.

Aryan tried to name what he felt and could not find a word that fit. It was not only jealousy, though jealousy was in it. It was something older and quieter and worse. It was the feeling of watching something you love begin to turn, very slowly, toward another source of light.

He said nothing. He smiled. He showed up. He ate his dinner and laughed at the right moments and went back to his room and lay in the dark and thought about a bench by a banyan tree and the sound of someone exhaling, finally, all the way out.

The conversation happened on a September evening at their bench. The campus had gone quiet and Priya had been somewhere inside herself all week, and Aryan, who had been pretending not to notice, finally said, simply: "Tell me."

She looked at him for a long time. She had been trying to gather herself to do this for a while.

She told him she was confused. She told him nothing had happened. She told him her own feelings were frightening her, that she had not chosen them, that she did not understand them, that she was sorry, that she needed time. She was not saying this was an ending. She could not say what it was.

She told him all of this carefully, choosing every word, refusing to wound him more than the truth itself would wound him.

He listened. He did not interrupt her once. When she finished, the campus was fully dark.

"Okay," he said. Just that one word.

He walked back to his room and sat on the edge of his bed for a long time without turning the light on. Not okay. Not even close to okay. But it had been the only word available to him that was both true and kind at the same time.

The weeks that followed were the strangest of his life. Everything looked exactly the same, the same corridors, the same faces, the same canteen smells, but the world had tilted just slightly on its axis, just enough that nothing was quite level anymore.

He watched Priya and Rohan grow close. He watched it the way you watch the weather, knowing you cannot stop it, not looking away, going very still inside.

He did not disappear. That was the decision he made, quietly, on one of those lightless nights: he would not make himself smaller or more absent. He would not vanish from his own life. He had been here. He would stay.

He got up every morning. He went to his classes. He read his books. He wrote long, ungainly, furious things in the small hours that he never showed anyone. He let time pass. He let himself grieve, privately, with the particular dignity of someone who understands that grief deserves its room but does not deserve to be handed the whole house.

There is a particular kind of loneliness in loving someone you still see every day. Not the loneliness of absence, that is its own, cleaner kind of pain. This was the loneliness of presence. Of sitting at the same table. Laughing at the same jokes. Knowing, the whole time,

that the thing that had once been yours had become, quietly and irreversibly, someone else's.

He learned, in those months, more about himself than he had in all the years before. He learned that he was stronger than he had believed, not in the hard, proud way, but in the stubborn, ordinary way. The way a tree is strong. Not because it never bends, but because it holds its roots even when everything above the ground is bending.

He also learned that loving someone does not require their presence to remain real. The love he had for Priya did not disappear when she chose another. It changed shape. It became something quieter and less urgent and, in certain ways, more honest, because it was no longer attached to any hope of return. It was simply what it was. A feeling, clean and free of agenda.

He kept going.

CHAPTER FOUR

One Love, Still

One Love · ARP Blogs

By the time final year settled in, the shape of things had changed. Not dramatically. Not the way stories announce their turns. Just quietly, the way seasons change, you look up one morning and something is different, and you realise it has been different for a while, and you simply hadn't said so out loud.

Priya and Rohan were together. It was not announced. It did not need to be. It was simply present, the way real things are present, not as a statement, but as a fact of the air.

Aryan knew. He had known before it was quite true. He carried the knowledge the way you carry something that no longer hurts the way it used to, not without pain, but differently. Dully. Without the acute edge it had once had.

The pain did not shrink the way people promise it will. Pain does not shrink. It changes shape. It went from sharp to dull to something that was not quite hurt at all but was closer to sorrow, and sorrow, he discovered, was a different thing entirely. Sorrow has weight but no edges. You can hold it. It will not cut you. It is simply heavy, and eventually you grow strong enough that the weight becomes something you carry without noticing, most of the time.

He began to write. Really write, not the angry, ungainly things of those first months, but actual work. Pages and pages. He sat at his desk in the early mornings, in the hour before the campus woke up, and wrote with the kind of focus that only comes when something that has been blocked inside you finally finds its opening and pours through.

He wrote about a boy who loved a girl and lost her, not to cruelty, not to betrayal, but to the ordinary, devastating fact of someone else arriving. He wrote about what it is to love someone without being able to ask for anything in return. He wrote about the strange, exhausting, ultimately beautiful work of continuing to be a person in the world after the thing that anchored you to it has quietly shifted.

His professor called him in after one of the pieces and said, "Whoever you wrote this for, it shows." He smiled and said nothing. Some things you are not ready to say out loud, and that is fine.

Priya remained his friend. Not immediately. Not easily. But she remained. She was too honest for pretense and he was too tired for bitterness, and between those two truths, something real managed to survive.

She apologised to him properly one December afternoon, in the library, in the same quiet, precise way she did everything that mattered to her. She said she was sorry she had hurt him. She said she had not wanted to. She said she had not been able to stop what she felt, but she knew that did not mean it had not cost him something real.

He believed her. That was the thing about Priya, she had never, in all the time he had known her, said a single word she did not mean.

"I know," he told her.

"Are you okay?" she asked.

He thought about it genuinely, because she had always given him her real attention and he had always tried to give her the same. "Not yet," he said. "But I think I will be. I think I already am, a little."

She nodded. They sat with their books open. The library was warm and quiet around them. They were not entirely comfortable. They were not entirely uncomfortable. They were somewhere in the honest middle, which is, he had come to believe, where most worthwhile things live.

He graduated on a morning in June. The sky was the deep clear blue that only happens on certain June mornings, and the lawn smelled of jasmine and freshly cut grass, and his parents were somewhere in the crowd, his mother waving with her whole arm, nothing held back, nothing restrained, the way she had always loved him, with absolutely everything she had.

He walked across the stage. He shook the offered hands and collected his certificate and adjusted the ridiculous flat cap and walked back out into the crowd and the noise and the photographs.

And standing there in the sunshine, in the joyful chaos of endings, he did something he had not planned to do.

He thought of Priya.

He thought of her without the old ache, or rather, with what the old ache had become over time. Something smaller. Something softer. Something that felt less like a wound and more like a scar, present, always present, but no longer bleeding. Healed into something that was almost, almost, its own kind of beautiful.

He thought of the bench by the banyan tree. He thought of November rain and roasted peanuts and a notebook half-filled with careful handwriting. He thought of what it had felt like to say the true thing out loud for the very first time, the particular, terrifying lightness of it, and to have it said back to him by the one person he had wanted to hear it from.

For a while, they had loved each other. Fully and honestly and without qualification. And nothing that had come after, none of it, could reach back through time and unmake that. It had happened. It was real. It would always have been real.

He looked for his mother in the crowd. She was still waving.

He raised his hand and waved back.

He was twenty-two years old. He had loved someone completely and been left and survived it, and now the whole enormous, open rest of his life was standing in the June light, waiting for him. Patient, and open, and full of things he had not yet imagined.

He walked toward it.

The heart does not love less for having loved before.

*It loves differently, more wisely, more gently,
more honestly than it could have without the breaking.*

Love does not end. It transforms.

It becomes the quiet ground beneath everything you do.

End

Acknowledgements

A book is never made alone. Even the most solitary writing is, at its core, a conversation, with memory, with the people you carry inside you, and with the reader you are writing toward without yet knowing their name.

I owe a debt I cannot properly repay to everyone who ever let me love them, and just as importantly, to everyone who let me lose them. Both are teachers. Loss, I have come to understand, is not the opposite of love. It is love's most honest lesson.

To the friends who sat with me in the difficult months and did not ask me to be fine before I was actually fine, you gave me something I did not know I needed until I had it. I remain grateful. I expect I always will.

To the teachers who taught me that feeling deeply is not weakness but material, that the things which hurt the most are often the things most worth writing about, thank you for that permission. I did not take it lightly.

To every reader who picks this up carrying something they have not said out loud yet, I hope you find a corner of yourself somewhere in these pages. I hope it helps, even a little. You are not alone in what you are feeling.

To love itself, which is stubborn and inconvenient and absolutely worth every complicated thing it costs.

ARP Blogs, 2026

About the Author

ARP Blogs studied literature, though the first thing to say about that is that most of what was learned about it happened outside the classroom, on benches, in canteens, in the long and unstructured hours that university life offers and that most people, quite reasonably, spend on other things.

One Love is a first novel. It was written over two years, in the early mornings before the city woke up and reclaimed its noise. It was written in order to understand something that had already been felt but could not yet be said. Whether it has been said now is a question that remains, pleasantly, open.

The stories most worth telling are the quiet ones, the ones that do not announce themselves as important, that do not arrive with great noise, but simply sit down beside you and tell you the truth without making a production of it.

ARP Blogs lives in India. Reads everything. Takes tea too strong and time too casually, and has made peace with both.

One Love · First Edition · ARP Blogs · 2026

*Some love stories end at the last page.
This one begins there.*

When Aryan meets Priya on the first day of second year, he is not looking for anything. He finds her anyway.

For two years, their love is quiet and certain, the kind that feels so real and so solid that it seems impossible it could ever shift. Then Rohan arrives. And everything does.

One Love is the story of what happens after the heart breaks, not the dramatic, announced kind of breaking, but the slow and ordinary kind. The kind you live through mostly in private. The kind that, if you let it, teaches you everything worth knowing about who you are.

This is a story about losing someone. And about finding, in what remains, yourself.

LITERARY FICTION · ARP BLOGS

ARP Blogs · 2026 · India